White in cultures and traditions

White is a colour people long thought of as "obvious". Purity, a wedding, innocence. Behind its reputation, though, are **more stories about fashion, commerce and faith than about the colour itself**. Let us visit a few places and read them carefully.

This chapter therefore shows **two levels**. First, how white is read in different **cultures**, and then how **traditional systems** look at it, using it as an image, not as instructions. What is verified history and what is later interpretation, I say in each part.

White in different cultures

England

Queen Victoria married on 10 February **1840** in a white satin dress with Honiton lace. She is often cited as the one who introduced the white wedding dress, but that is not accurate. White had been worn earlier and Victoria's wide press coverage rather popularised it.

From a time when fashion became a custom and the custom "always".

White here is **a tradition with its own biography**.

Greece

Ancient statues and buildings were often painted. The colour wore off over time and what remained of antiquity was a white idea that classicism took over. Traces of colour were found, for example, on the Parthenon and on Aegina.

From a place that gave us a white ideal, and perhaps never had it itself.

White can be **a later beauty that we added ourselves**.

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Rome

The toga candida was a toga cleaned with chalk to a dazzling white. It was worn by candidates for public office. The Latin word candida means pure white and gave rise to the word candidate.

The Roman poet Persius is said to have spoken of it mockingly as "chalk-whitened ambition". White has thus long carried a suspicion of showing off as well.

White here is **an invitation for a person to show themselves**.

China

In some Chinese and other East Asian traditions white has a place in mourning ceremonies. Specific customs differ by place, family and religion.

A colour that may remind you of the beginning of a marriage thus accompanies farewell elsewhere.

White here is **a reminder that we read colours in the language of the environment** in which we grew up.

White in traditional systems

Every tradition looks at white **a little differently**, but all take it seriously. It is an old symbolic language and an inspiration, not a healing manual.

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Traditional Chinese medicine

In the traditional five-element system white is linked with metal, autumn, the lungs, the large intestine and grief. For work with colour we can draw near the theme of receiving and letting go. Inhaling and exhaling alternate. An autumn tree also does not keep all its leaves just because it put so much work into them in spring.

How it relates to white. With people it is usually more complicated. We hold on to things, roles and obligations because "it has always been so". You can free up one shelf, put down an unrequested duty or notice that you keep a certain thing mainly out of guilt or habit. A white or light ground helps because on it you see better what you have kept. **White will not cleanse anything for you.**

And what if I asked you now?

"What do I want to keep and what do I no longer need to have constantly in front of my eyes?"

When something has ended

After a break-up, a loss or the end of a long period you may long for a lighter room. Not because you want to deny your previous life. Perhaps you need every object not to remind you of it. Or on the contrary you do not want to change anything. That too may be important at the time.

Autumn is not the end

A white fabric, a new cover or an empty spot on the wall can accompany a change. **You do not have to choose one position forever.**

Traditional Chinese medicine uses the elements as an image. It is not a diagnosis and does not replace a doctor.

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Ayurveda

Ayurveda is an old Indian teaching about health. It describes a person by three types of “energy”, the so-called doshas. Vata (air, restlessness), pitta (fire, intensity) and kapha (earth and water, heaviness). Colours are not assigned to the doshas uniformly in the classical texts, so here you read **modern interpretations**, not an old table.

How it relates to white. In some yogic and Ayurvedically inspired interpretations white is used as an image of purity, clarity and calm. What is interesting for us is what you imagine under purity. Fewer disturbing stimuli? Honesty? Or the pressure of having no "bad" emotions?

Pitta

This describes a woman who is purposeful, quick and thorough, who flares up easily. Matte white and soft materials can feel cooling. A dazzling glossy white and sharp contrast may, on the contrary, irritate.

- **Matt and soft**
  Calming, as a base.
- **Beware of glare**
  Gloss can be one more stimulus.

Vata

This describes a woman who is imaginative and quick, but restless and often cold. A cold white can feel empty. Cream and wool add warmth. **It is best to notice how you really feel in it.**

- **Cream and wool**
  Soft and warmer than pure white.
- **Evening and sleep**
  Warm light and soft textiles.

Kapha

This describes a woman who is calm, steady and patient, but who easily grows heavy. Light surfaces can lighten a space, but let them not be cold. **Add movement and colour to them.**

- **A light base**
  Lightens a heavy environment.
- **Add colour**
  Green or yellow as an accent.

We will therefore not make white a universal ban or a remedy for a particular dosha. More interesting is whether a specific form brings you comfort, or weighs on you.

An online test will not reliably determine your dosha. If you are more interested, consult a qualified Ayurvedic practitioner. It is not treatment.

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A Jungian view

Carl Gustav Jung, the Swiss psychiatrist, understood colours as symbols that have two layers. A personal one (what we have experienced with the colour) and one shared by all people (images that repeat across ages and cultures).

Jung did not describe white as a colour of its own. What I write next is my own reflection in the spirit of his thinking, not his statement. In alchemy, after the nigredo comes the albedo, the whitening. In his works on alchemy Jung interpreted it as an image of purification and new light after the dark phase.

How it relates to white. In symbolic language you can read white as **the colour of possibility and of space before a decision**. When you think about it, ask what in it is yours and what belongs to the expectations of others.

What you can take from it. Jung did not want colours turned into a dictionary. **We always ask what it means for you.** The same white can be relief for one woman and pressure for another. Jung's ideas about colours are a symbolic frame, not verified science.

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Feng shui

Feng shui is the Chinese art of arranging space so that it is good to live in. In feng shui interpretations white is commonly linked with metal and can accompany the theme of clarity, simplicity and discernment. Schools differ in the assignments, so take it as one possibility.

White is like paper

A little gives a space light, a whole room turns it into an examination room. The question is whether the arrangement helps you live, or whether you are trying to live so as not to spoil it.

Simple tips

- **Add texture**
  Wood, knitwear and linen can change the impression even without striking colours. The gain is the variety and personality of the space.
- **Change the lighting**
  Warmer evening light and more diffuse lamps do more than another colour.
- **Watch the surface**
  Matte white feels different from glossy. Gloss shows fingerprints and dazzles.
- **Leave something of your own**
  A picture, a book, a plant or a thing that is truly yours.
- **Compare shades in the room**
  A cold white next to cream looks bluish and cream in turn looks yellowish.
- **Try textiles first**
  Before you repaint a wall, try a throw or a larger sample.

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What people say and what holds true

MYTH White is always clean and calm.

TRUTH Pure white under cold light can feel like a waiting room. A warm white with a creamy tinge is more homely.

MYTH White walls will make a room bigger.

TRUTH Light walls reflect more light, so the room feels airier. They cannot make it bigger, though, and white without textures can be empty.

MYTH White does not suit children and animals.

TRUTH It does, if you choose a washable paint and add a few darker elements. The whole room need not be like a gallery.

What white goes well with

- **Wood and brown**
  A more bodily, warmer impression. It prevents the room from looking like an examination room.
- **Green**
  Plants in front of a light wall look alive.
- **Black**
  A clear contrast that helps tell things apart. Watch the amount.
- **Pink**
  Softness or freshness depending on the shade.
- **Gold**
  A festive detail. Too much shine can look ostentatious.
- **Blue**
  Fresh and calm. Without warmth it can be cold.

Elements

- **Metal**
  White is its natural stand-in. Make sure it does not outweigh.
- **Water**
  Black and dark blue deepen it.
- **Earth**
  Brown and yellow warm it.
- **Wood**
  Green and wood enliven it.

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Feng shui room by room

Living room

What works. White walls can let a picture, books and plants stand out.

What to watch for. If the sofa, floor, curtains and furniture are white too, the room can feel like a flat before the keys are handed over.

A simple tip. Add different surfaces and a few things that are truly yours.

Kitchen

What works. White cupboards can create a light base.

What to watch for. On some surfaces you will see every fingerprint and begin to feel that something is always unfinished.

A simple tip. Notice the material and maintenance. A matte or textured surface behaves differently from a glossy one.

Bedroom

What works. White bedding can recall purity and rest.

What to watch for. Cold sharp light, glossy surfaces and bare walls, however, can shift the room toward an examination room.

A simple tip. Try warmer evening lighting, a cream throw or a wooden headboard. You need not abolish white.

Children's room

What works. A white wall can be the beginning of a story.

What to watch for. It should not be a ban on its continuation.

A simple tip. Leave room for pictures and the child's choice.

Study

What works. In a study white can be a clear ground.

What to watch for. If a desk or screen dazzles you against a dark surrounding, it tends to be tiring.

A simple tip. Adjust the light and contrast. White should not replace a well-prepared workplace.

Bathroom

What works. White can help give a lighter impression.

What to watch for. When strong light reflects from glossy tiles into your eyes, it can be unpleasant.

A simple tip. More diffuse lighting and more matte surfaces will help.

And try answering now

"What does white at home allow me and what does it forbid me?"

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